**Advanced & Post Reading Material (APRM)**
**EPP-I, 2025-26, BELH0020 GLA University, Mathura**
**Module II: Subject-Verb Agreement**

## Subject-Verb Agreement

Are the following sentences correct?

- She ***are*** my best friend.
- They ***is*** going to watch movie today
- I ***is*** drinking water.

Sentences written above are not correct as the verbs in these sentences don't agree with their respective subjects. In a sentence, the verb must agree with its subject in number and person.

Every word in the sentence is used under a pattern or scheme that is called agreement. Subject and verb, the two most important elements of the sentence should also be in agreement.

| Condition & Rules | Examples | Agreement |
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| 1. The verb must agree with its subject in both **number** and **person**.<br>If the subject is singular, the **verb must be singular**.<br>If the subject is plural, the **verb must be plural**. | **She is** my best friend.<br>**I am** drinking water.<br>**They are** going to watch movie today. | She (Singular Subject) is (Singular verb)<br>I (Singular Subject) am (Singular verb)<br>They (Plural Subject) are **(**plural verb) |
| 2. Subjects and Verbs are placed separately: Eliminating middle phrases and clauses to identify the subject. Verbs are used according to their subjects. | Phrase<br>The **weather** in mountainous regions **is** treacherous during the winter.<br>**A box** of sweet mangoes **is** in the car.<br>Clause<br>**Storms** that occur during winter **cause** deep snow drifts.<br>**The boys** standing in the corner **are** hockey players. | Weather (Singular Subject) is (Singular verb)<br>A box (Singular Subject) is (Singular verb)<br>Storms (Plural subject) Cause (plural verb)<br>The boys (Plural subject) are (plural verb) |

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| **3. Subject has two or more parts: and vs. additive phrases:**<br>When two or more singular subjects are joined by **'and'**, they form a **compound subject** and take a **plural verb**.<br>**Example:**<br>Ram **and** Shyam **are** good friends.<br>**Exception:**<br>When the paired words joined by **'and'** express **a single idea or a unified concept**, they take a **singular verb**.<br>**Examples:**<br>• Bread and butter **is** my favourite breakfast.<br>• Law and order **has** been restored.<br>• Slow and steady **wins** the race.<br><br>Some such pair expressions include: *bread and butter, rice and curry, horse and carriage, crown and glory, rise and fall, law and order,* etc. | Silver, gold **and** other metals **are** mined in Western Australia.<br><br>**Slow and steady wins** the race. | Silver, gold **and** other metals (Plural Subject) are (Plural verb)<br><br>Slow and Steady (plural subject) wins (Singular verb) |

| Condition & Rules | Examples | Agreement |
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| **4. With additive phrases such as-** along with, in addition to, as well as, together with, unlike, nothing but **Verb is used according to subjec that is placed first** | **Manisha** as well as her sisters **has** chosen IT Branch.<br>**They** along with their friend **have** filled in the examination form. | Manisha (singular Subject) has (singular verb)<br>They (plural subject) have (plura verb) |
| **5.** When subject follows the verb, especially the sentence starts with there, here, this, that, it. Verb is always used according to the subject. | **There are** many **new courses** available in the field of computer science.<br>Here **begins** the unforgettable extravaganza of **annual youth fest** in Engineering College. | There (Existential subject), new courses (Plural subject) are (Plural Verb)<br>Dummy Subject here annual youth fest (Singular Subject) begins (Singular verb) |

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| **6. Subjects Connected by "or," "nor," "either...or," "neither...nor," or "none but"**<br><br>When two or more subjects are connected by **or**, **nor**, **either...or**, **neither...nor**, or **none but**, the **verb agrees with the subject nearest to it**.<br>This rule is known as the **Principle of Proximity** (or the Rule of Nearest Subject).<br><br>**Examples:**<br><br>• Either Rohan **or** his friends **are** going to the party.<br>• Neither the teachers **nor** the principal **was** present.<br>• None but his friends were invited. | Neither **Rohan** nor **his friends have submitted** the assignment.<br><br>Rohan or **Sonu** is a good pick for the team. | His Friends (plural subject) have submitted (plural verb form)<br>Sonu (Singular Subject) goes (Singular verb) |
| **7. When the subject is an indefinite pronoun**<br>'each', 'either', 'neither' 'another', 'anyone', 'anybody', 'anything', 'someone', 'somebody', 'something', 'one', 'everyone', 'everybody', 'everything', 'no one', 'no one', nobody', nothing' Singular verb is used.<br><br>When the pronouns 'both', 'many', 'few', 'several', 'other', are used in a sentence,<br>P**lural verb is used**<br><br>Words like 'none', 'any', 'all', 'more', 'most', 'some' **take singular or plural verb, depending on the context** | **Everyone** in the group **has** a job to do to complete the project in time.<br><br>**Nobody is going** to help Shanaya in Preparing dinner tonight.<br><br>**Many of the students** in the group **work** consistently.<br><br>**All** of the project **work was** done by the students of B. Tech III year.<br><br>**All** the **projects were** submitted in time by B. Tech III year students. | Everyone (Singular subject) am (Singular verb)<br><br>Nobody (Singular Subject) is going (Singular verb<br><br>Many of the students (plural Subject)<br>Work (Plural verb)<br><br>Work (Singular Subject) was (singular verb)<br><br>Projects (Plural subject) were (plural form of verb) |

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| **8. Subject is a collective noun or non- count noun** Collective nouns (e.g., team, committee, family, crowd, audience, government) **singular verb is used when referred as single unit otherwise plural verb is used.** | The **committee was** unanimous in the decision to suspend the students who had cheated in the examination.<br><br>The **committee were** divided in the decision to suspend the students who had cheated in the examination. | Committee (Collective noun/singular subject) was (singular verb)<br><br>Committee (Collective noun/Plural subject Were (Plural verb) |
| **9.**An **uncountable noun** (e.g. sugar, water, news)<br>**Singular verb is used** | Two spoons of **sugar is** added to make one cup tea. | Sugar (non-count/singular subject)<br>is (singular verb) |
| **10. <u>Inverted Subject-Verb Order</u>**<br>The sentence may begin<br>• with a prepositional phrase<br>• the verb forms of *do*<br>• by adverb<br>To identify subject, ask *Who?* or *What?* is doing the action and the verb is used accordingly- | In the center of the mall **stand four statues**.<br>Do the **students consent** to the terms in the contract of participation in the contest?<br>So quickly **does he** answer the questions in the quiz that we all are surprised | four statues (Plural Subject)<br>stand (Plural verb)<br>Students (Plural Subject)<br>Do consent (Plural verb)<br>He (Singular subject) does answer (Singular verb) |
| **11. <u>With Linking Verbs</u>**<br><br>In sentences with **linking verbs** (verbs that link or join the subject with an adjective, a noun, or a pronoun),<br><br>**The verb agrees with the subject, not with the subject complement**. | Jake's favorite **food is** chocolate chip cookies.<br><br>**Chocolate chip cookies are** Jake's favorite food. | Food (singular subject) is (singular verb)<br><br>Chocolate chip cookies (Plural Subject) are (Plural Verb) |
| **12. <u>With Relative Pronouns</u>**<br><br>When using a relative pronoun (*who, which, that, what, whatever,* and *whoever*) to introduce a dependent clause, that **verb in the clause should agree in number with the pronoun's antecedent** (the word to which the pronoun refers). | Jake is the only **one** who **has** a security pass.<br><br>This is one of the **books** that **are required.** | One (singular subject)<br>has (singular verb)<br>Books (plural subject) Are required (plural verb) |

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| **13. <u>Plural subject specific to amount, sum, distance etc</u>.**<br>When plural subject explains specific amount, sum, distance, quantity, time, period as a whole<br>**Singular verb is used** | **Five miles i**s not a long distance to go by car.<br>**Five years is** the maximum sentence for that offense. | Five miles (Singular subject) denoting specific distance<br>is (singular verb)<br>Five years (Singular subject)<br>is (Singular verb) |
| **14.** Same subject is referred to by two singular nouns denoted by one article-<br>**Singular verb is used**<br>Different subjects are referred to by two singular nouns denoted by two articles **Plural Verb is used** | **The professor and HOD is** presiding over the meeting for discussing the strategies to face the situation.<br>**The Professor and the HOD are** presiding over the meeting for discussing the strategies to face the situation. | The Professor (Singular Subject/Same person) is presiding (Singular verb)<br>The professor and the head (Plural Subject/different persons)<br>are (plural verb) |
| **15. Some nouns appear to be singular, but they have plural meaning as: c**attle, poultry, gentry, police, infantry<br>**Here, plural verb is used.** | **Police have** helped in distributing food for the poor people.<br>**The infantry have** marched forward. | Police (Plural Subject)<br>have (plural verb)<br>The infantry (Plural Subject)<br>have (plural verb) |
| **16. Some nouns are always used as singular as:**<br>Scenery, furniture, advice, information, hair, luggage, jewelry, baggage<br>**Here, singular verb is used.** | The furniture was worn and rustic with wooden frames and upholstered cushions. | Furniture (singular subject)<br>was (singular verb) |
| **17. With fractions,** percentages **and indefinite quantifiers (e.g., all, few, many, much, some), the** verb **agrees with the preceding** noun **or clause:** | **One-third** of this note **is** taken up with statistical analysis.<br>**Much** of the book **seems** relevant to this study. | One- third (Singular subject)<br>is (Singular verb)<br>Much (Singular subject)<br>Seems (Singular verb) |

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| **18. The following words and their compounds are always singular and require a singular verb:**<br>Body (anybody, everybody, nobody, somebody)<br>Thing (anything, everything, nothing, something) One (anyone, everyone, none, no one, someone) | Everybody in the office has tickets.<br><br>Something is wrong with him these days.<br><br>Everyone is required to clear their dues. | |